Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "An Invocation"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Coleridge's poem include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
envoy,
esemplastic power,
feminine rhyme,
iambic pentameter,
imagination,
inversion,
invocation,
metaphor,
metonymy,
muse,
quatrain,
syncope,
synecdoche, and
tone.

The brevity of and isolation of Coleridge's addressing the "Sweet Muse" suggests an envoy, perhaps for an ongoing body of work. The student might recognize this possibility in the appositive "companion of my every hour," which suggests both the poet's conscious life and his sleeping. The fullness of the relationship between the poet and the muse is further suggested in "Voice of my Joy! Sure soother of the sigh!" (line 2), a pairing of adulatory figurative phrases that gives direct responsibility for both uplifting joy and succor (whenever the metonymic sigh prevails) to the Sweet Muse.

The young contestant might concentrate on the role of the muse—here unspecified, but in the context of Coleridge's romantic focus on natural world, nature herself. The muse is both a companion in the creation of the poem (lines 1 and 6), which seems to be an exercise of the esemplastic power, and also something that helps the poet see the world with an impartial eye (line 4). The poet, while immersed in the inspiring vision, comes to see "the tale"—nature, perhaps including his poetry—as a unified whole.

The adventurous young writer might seek to compare the relatively abstract source of inspiration to which "An Invocation" is addressed to the more concrete source of inspiration in Coleridge's "Kubla Kahn," "the damsel with a dulcimer."